Project 2 – Acme Analytics Linux Platform

Day 12 · Phase 4: CPU limit (CPUQuota) · the 3 limit tests on one page

Muhammad Bilal Javed · 4 November 2026 · study copy

Project	Acme Analytics – hardened, observable and recoverable Linux platform
Phase	4 – Processes, signals and limits
Hosts worked on	app01 (one session 3 Nov 22:15 → 4 Nov 01:30: hard limit, OOM scores, soft limit, CPU limit)
Status	Phase 4 🟡 – Steps 4.1–4.4 ✅ · Step 4.5: concept ✅ · lab: cgroup tree ✅ · hard memory limit ✅ · soft memory limit ✅ · **CPU limit** ✅ – permanent limits on stor01 next
Author	Muhammad Bilal Javed

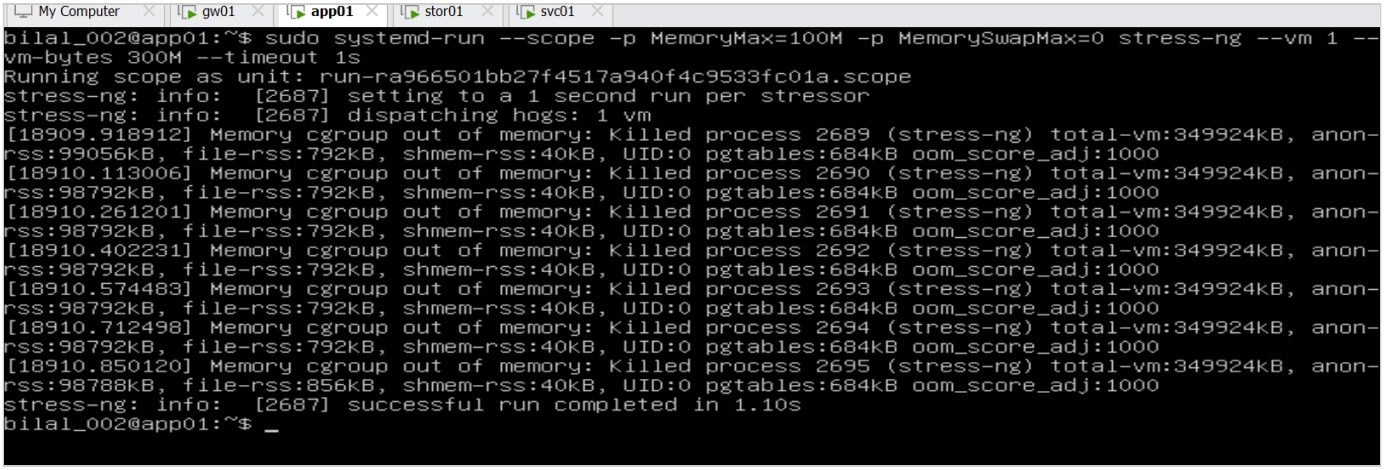
> **How to read this report.** 💡 **In plain words** – the idea for any reader. 🔧 **Technical** – the settings and commands. 📸 **Evidence** – the real screenshot or diagram. Terms are explained in the glossary. Previous day: Day 11.

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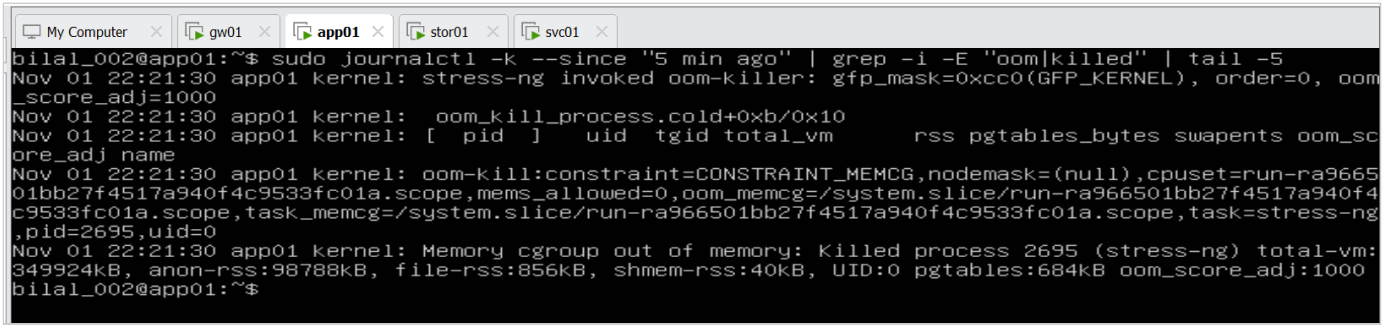
0. This session from the start (3 Nov 22:15 → 4 Nov 01:30) – tests 1 and 2

This session began on the evening of 3 November and continued past midnight. Tests 1 and 2 are documented in full in Day 11, section 4; the screenshots are repeated here so the whole session is in one place.

Test #1 – hard limit (MemoryMax=100M, no swap): KILLED

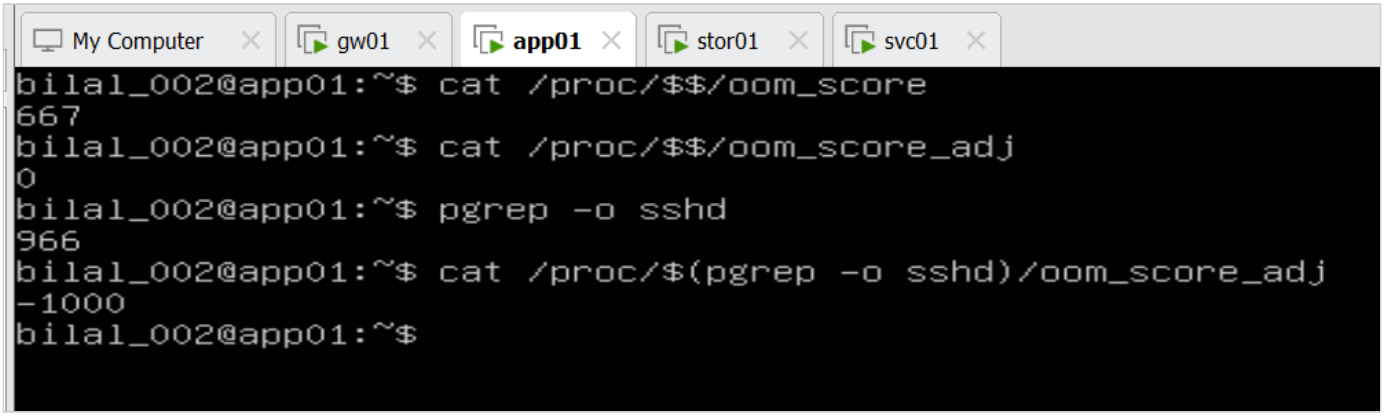


Test #1 – stress-ng killed at 100 MB



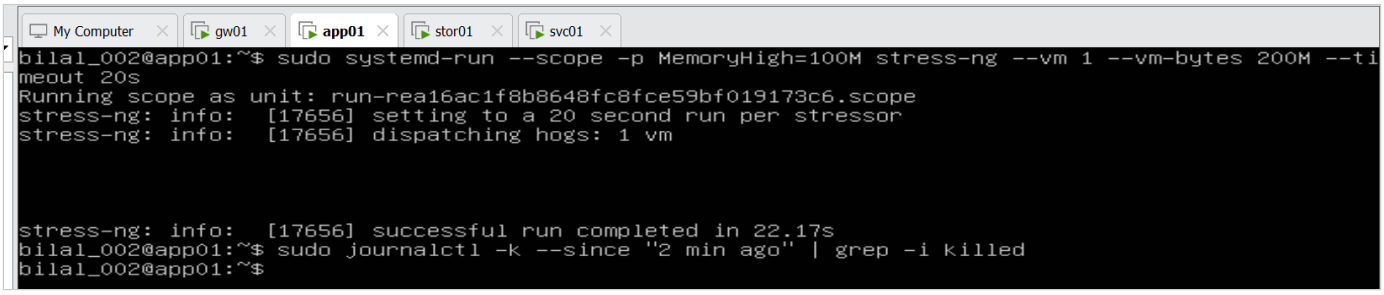
Test #1 – journal proof CONSTRAINT_MEMCG

Who is killed when a box is full – the OOM score checked on app01 (my bash 667, sshd protected at -1000)



oom_score check on app01

Test #2 – soft limit (MemoryHigh=100M): SLOWED, not killed (22.17 s instead of 20 s, no `Killed` line)



Test #2 – soft limit result

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1. Test #3 (app01) – CPU limit: throttled, never killed

💡 **In plain words:** CPU is not like memory. With `CPUQuota=20%` the box may use the CPU for 20 ms in every 100 ms; when its share is used up it simply **waits** for the next 100 ms – like mobile data after the monthly limit: slower, not cut off. Nothing is killed.

🔧 **Technical:**

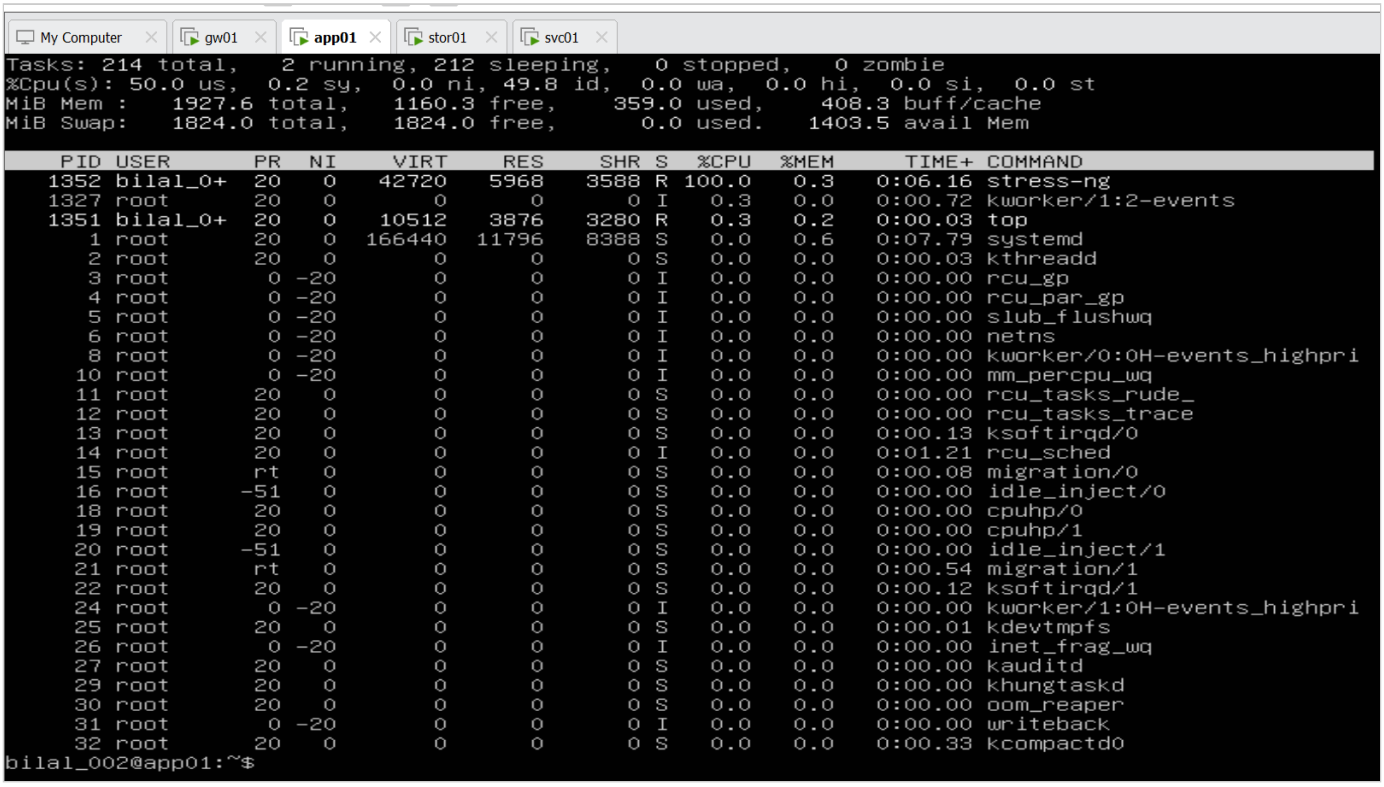
```
        # A) baseline — no limit
        stress-ng --cpu 1 --timeout 30s & sleep 2; top

        # B) with the limit
        sudo -v
        sudo systemd-run --scope -p CPUQuota=20% stress-ng --cpu 1 --timeout 60s & sleep 2; top

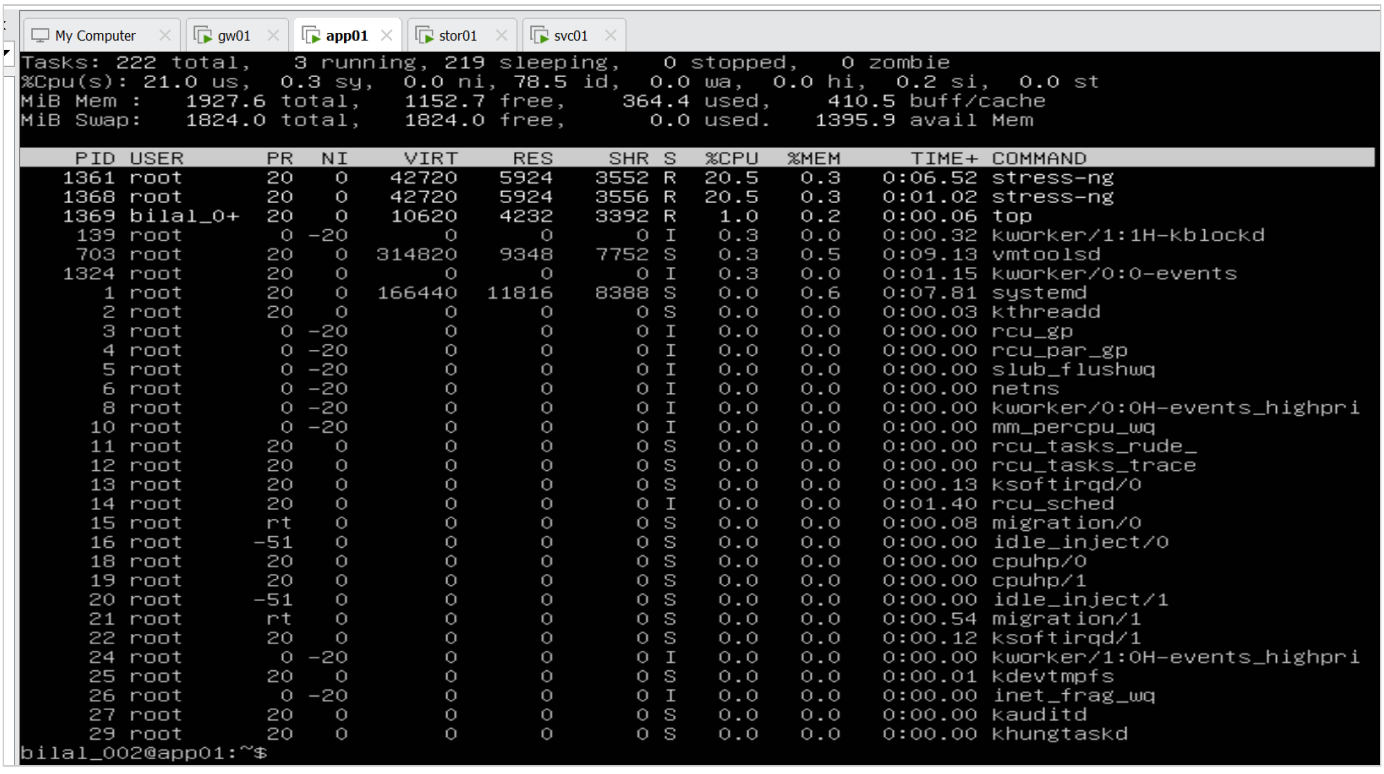
        # proof from the box itself (only while the test runs)
        sudo systemd-run --scope -p CPUQuota=20% stress-ng --cpu 1 --timeout 30s & sleep 2; cat /sys/fs/cgroup/
system.slice/run-*.scope/cpu.max
```

What I saw	Meaning
A: stress-ng **100.0 %**, `%Cpu(s): 50.0 us`	one full core busy – app01 has 2 cores, so one core = 50 % of the whole server
B: stress-ng **20.5 %**, `78.5 id`	throttled to the limit – the server is mostly idle, the job waits its turn
B: **two** stress-ng (PID 1361, 1368), **each 20.5 %**	test B was started twice → two boxes, each with its **own** 20 % – a limit belongs to its box
`cpu.max` → `20000 100000`	20 000 µs (20 ms) of CPU in every 100 000 µs (100 ms) = 20 %

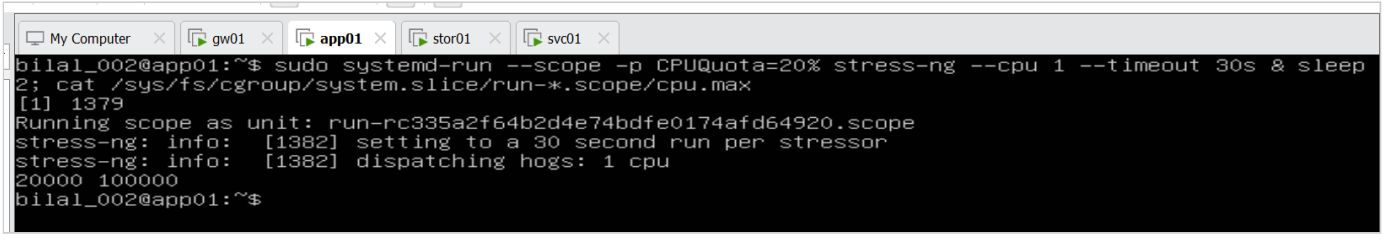
📸 **Evidence:**



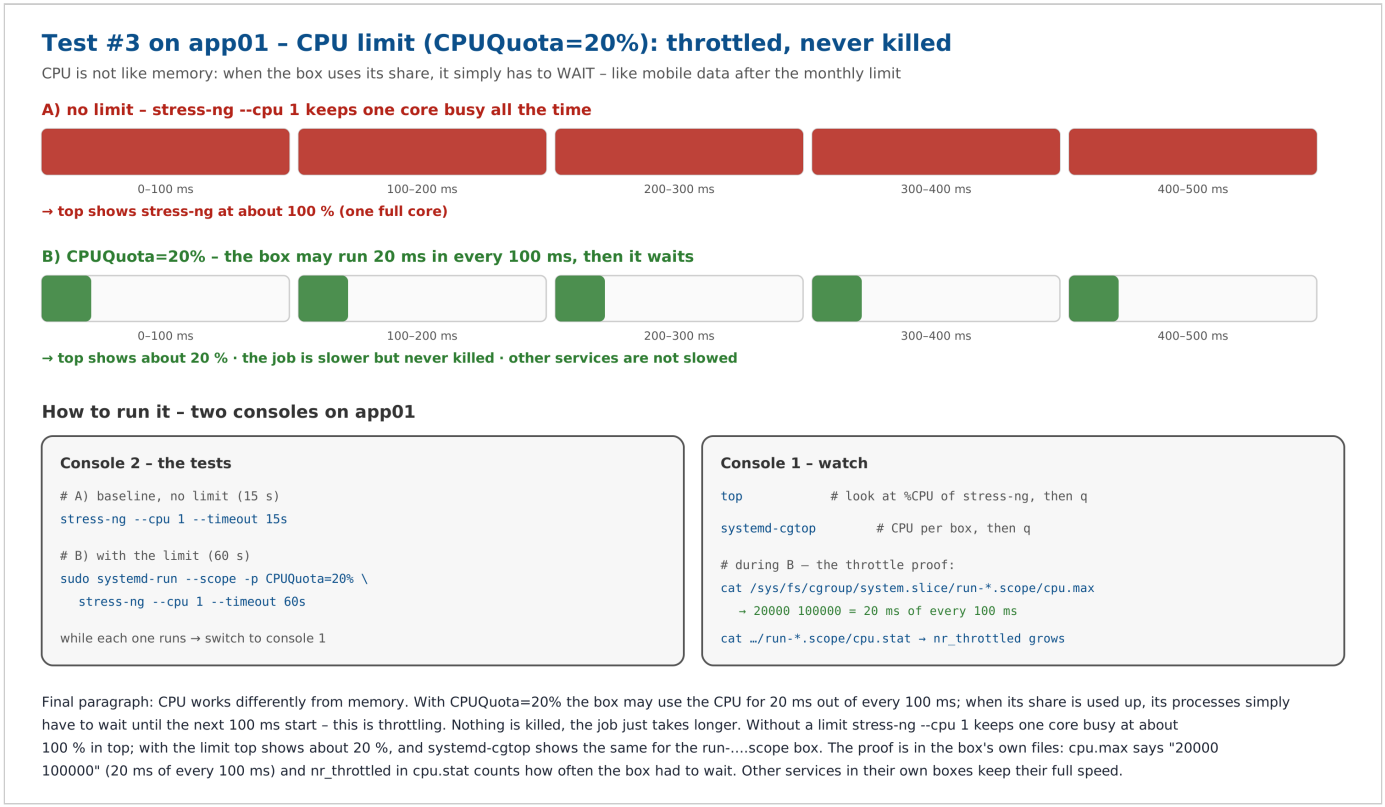
No limit – stress-ng at 100 %



CPUQuota=20% – stress-ng at 20.5 %



cpu.max – 20000 100000



Test #3 – how CPU throttling works

1.1 What went wrong on the way – and the fix

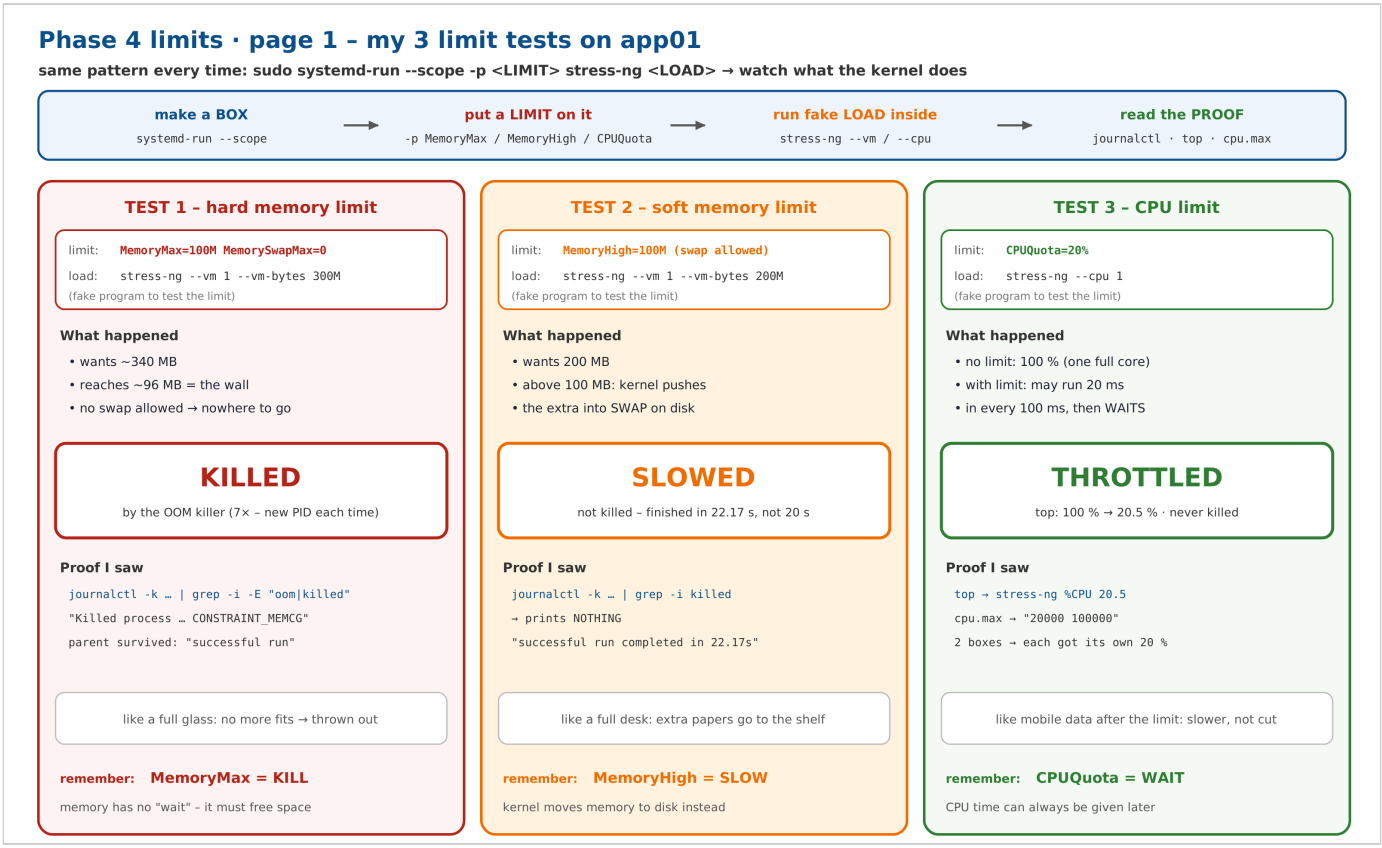
Problem	Cause	Fix
`top` showed no stress-ng, 99.8 % idle	`top` was opened after the test had finished – the stress-ng messages printed over the prompt and made it look busy	start and watch in one line: `cmd & sleep 2; top`
background sudo could get stuck	sudo asks for a password, which a background job cannot read	`sudo -v` first
`cat …/system.slice-run-*.scope/cpu.max`: No such file	a dash instead of a slash – and the box folder is deleted when the test ends	`system.slice/run-*.scope` while the test runs · Tab completes paths
app01 switched off by accident	–	nothing to clean up: the test box was a live change in RAM and was gone after the restart
switching consoles	–	click inside the VM, Alt+F1 / Alt+F2 (or `sudo chvt 2`)

2. The 3 limit tests – revision sheet

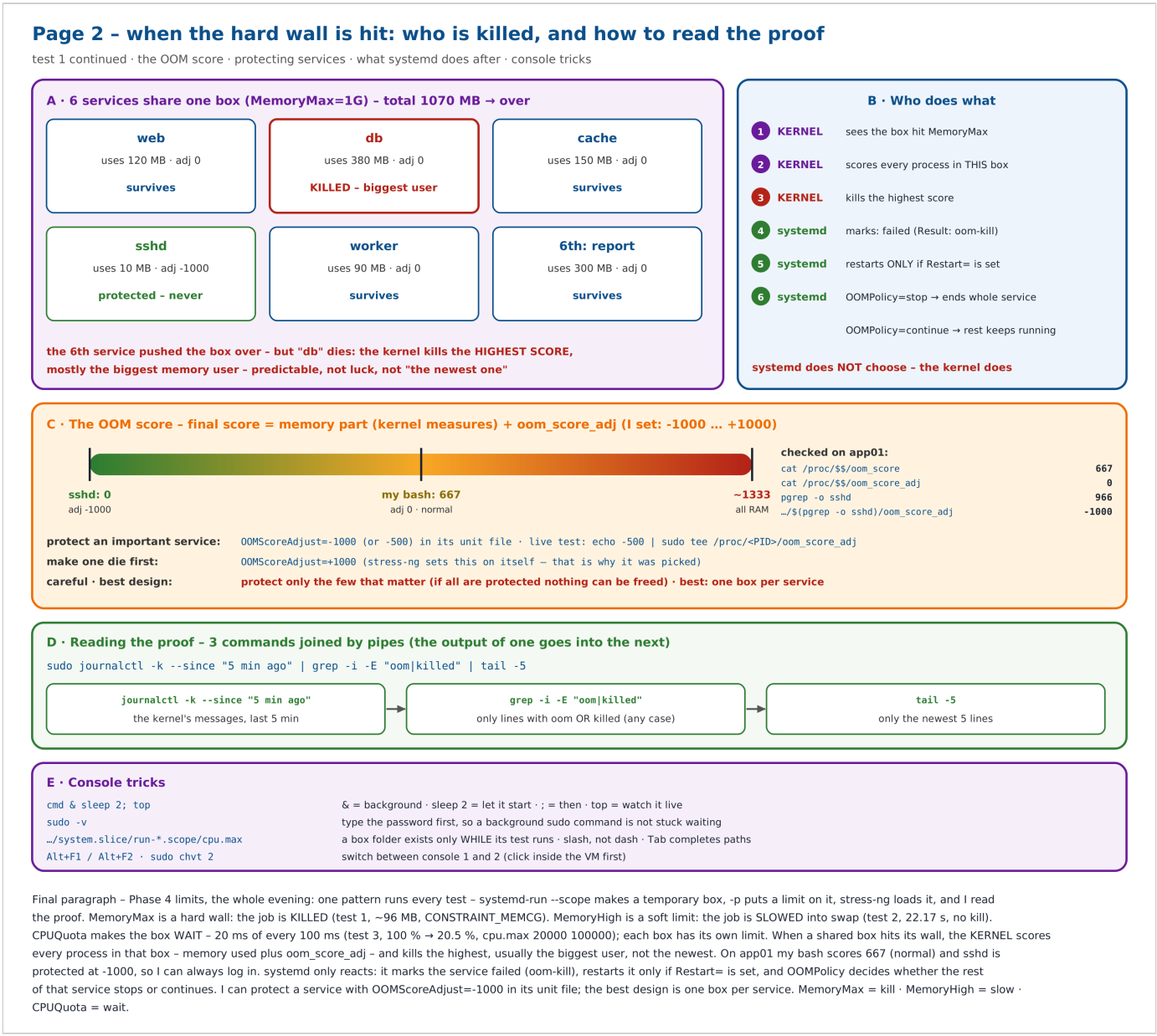
	Test 1	Test 2	Test 3
limit	`MemoryMax=100M` + no swap	`MemoryHigh=100M`	`CPUQuota=20%`
load	`stress-ng --vm 1 --vm-bytes 300M`	`stress-ng --vm 1 --vm-bytes 200M`	`stress-ng --cpu 1`
result	**KILLED** by the OOM killer at ~96 MB	**SLOWED** into swap – 22.17 s instead of 20 s	**THROTTLED** – 100 % → 20.5 %
proof	`CONSTRAINT_MEMCG` in the kernel log	no `Killed` line	`top`, `cpu.max = 20000 100000`
remember	MemoryMax = **kill**	MemoryHigh = **slow**	CPUQuota = **wait**

Memory cannot wait – too much memory must be freed (killed or swapped). CPU time can always be given later – too much CPU only waits.

📸 **The 2-page revision sheet** (page 2: who the OOM killer chooses, the OOM score, reading the proof, console tricks):



Phase 4 limits – page 1



Phase 4 limits – page 2

3. Key understanding (in my own words)

All three tests use one pattern: `systemd-run --scope` makes a temporary box, `-p` puts a limit on it, stress-ng creates fake load inside, and I read the proof. `MemoryMax` is a hard wall – the job is **killed** (test 1). `MemoryHigh` is a soft limit – the job is **slowed** into swap (test 2). `CPUQuota=20%` lets the box run 20 ms in every 100 ms (`cpu.max` = `20000 100000`): without a limit stress-ng used 100 % of one core, with it `top` showed 20.5 % – **throttled**, never killed, and two boxes each got their own 20 % because a limit belongs to its box. When a shared box hits its memory wall, the kernel kills the process with the highest OOM score (memory used + `oom_score_adj`), and systemd only reacts. MemoryMax = kill · MemoryHigh = slow · CPUQuota = wait.

4. Next

1. **Step 4 (stor01):** permanent limits on `archive-worker.service` – written into a file, so they survive a reboot.
2. First incident drill · L3 Problem in GLPI · snapshot `50-processes` → Phase 4 complete.